

Axiology Value Theory

Author: AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan.org — a group of people studying Madhyasth Darshan philosophy. Source repository: [raghavamohan/AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan](https://raghavamohan.com/AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan).

Edited on: July 28, 2026, 2:45 PM IST

The question: What is a value, where does value reside, how is value recognised and fulfilled, and what makes one evaluation correct and another mistaken? How does the Co-existentialism of Shri A. Nagraj compare with Advaita Vedanta, modern Western value theory, and the natural and social sciences?

This study examines value, evaluation, and the ordering of values in **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), as presented by **Shri A. Nagraj**, and compares its answers with **Advaita Vedanta**, **modern Western axiology and metaethics**, and **the natural and social sciences**.

[The Ontology of Coexistence](#) supplies the setting: Omnipresence, saturated units, form, properties, essential nature and *dharma*, the four orders, and the active structure of *jeevan*. [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) supplies the knowing sequence: knowing, believing, recognising, fulfilling, and evaluating. The present study asks the specifically axiological questions those two leave open. If a unit's essential nature already *is* its value, what work is left for evaluation? If value is objective, why does the darshan insist that only awakening evaluates correctly? And if happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss cannot be traded against one another, what kind of ordering do values have at all?

Madhyasth Darshan's value vocabulary is also used by several specialised studies in this collection. Ethics takes up justice, *dharma*, and right-use as conduct; Aesthetics takes up beauty and the aesthetic addition to useful things; Prosperity takes up production, exchange, and accumulation; Family Relationships takes up the individual relationship values in family life. This paper stays at the level those studies presuppose: what a value is, what kinds there are, how the kinds are ordered, and what makes an evaluation true.

Standpoint and scope

These studies are written from the standpoint of a **scientist and technologist** — someone trained to graduate-level **physics and mathematics**, at home with contemporary cosmology, quantum theory, conservation laws, and the logic of formal models.

From that background, a familiar picture of value is hard to avoid: **value appears to be something minds add to a valueless world** — a preference, a reward signal, a fitness proxy, or a social convention projected onto facts that contain none. Modern science is powerful on mechanism, measurement, and prediction; yet the is–ought gap, the status of well-being, and the question of whether anything is good independently of being wanted remain unresolved. The standpoint taken here does not treat those gaps as settled in favour of the view that value is merely projected.

The work begins where that picture leaves open questions — and asks whether Madhyasth Darshan offers a coherent alternative worth examining seriously. This paper reads the primary texts carefully,

states what follows from the darshan itself, and compares it in parallel with what we know from **physics and the natural and social sciences, Advaita Vedanta, and modern Western philosophy** (especially axiology, metaethics, welfare theory, and the economics of value). Physics and mathematics are **one leg** of that comparison, not the only one. The aim is rigorous comparative understanding — testing definitions, internal consistency, and fit with public knowledge — not persuasion or devotional endorsement.

These topical studies state the philosophy in clear, checkable prose first. A separate formal mathematical treatment may follow once the definitions and relations are stable across the studies; this paper does not assume or require that treatment.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

Madhyasth Darshan holds that value is not conferred by preference, command, or convention. A unit's value is its essential nature as that participates in coexistence, and it is present in every unit whether insentient or sentient. What the human being adds is not value but *evaluation*: the knowledge-order activity of recognising what a value is and whether it has been fulfilled. Value is therefore objective and universally distributed, while evaluation is fallible and depends on the evaluator's awakening. Almost every distinctive feature of the darshan's axiology follows from holding these two claims together.

1.1 Value as essentiality

Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad derives value from the ontology directly rather than introducing it as a separate moral topic. Existence is coexistence; every unit exists with beingness; and beingness in mutuality shows itself as complementarity, mutual recognition, and impression. Value enters at exactly that point:

“Entire beingness implies the essentiality of units in every plane and order. Essentiality refers to value.”

— SB, p. 50

Essentiality (*maulikta*) is what a unit distinctively is in the whole — the reading of form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma* developed in [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.3. To say that essentiality is value is to deny that value is an extra property layered on top of natural properties. It is the same fact described from the side of participation. SB restates this as a general claim about units:

“Value is established in every unit. Dharma is inseparable from the unit.”

— SB, p. 87

Essential nature manifests as values in every unit, insentient or sentient, and it is understood through cause and effect rather than by measurement alone (SB, p. 87). SB adds that value is what gets reciprocated: complementarity, mutual recognition, and impression occur only in mutuality, so the essen-

tiality of a unit is “regulated, protected, and universal because it is eternally present” (SB, p. 50). Value is thus relational without being subjective. It requires mutuality, not an observer’s approval. *Manav Karm Darshan* makes the same identification from the side of presence and meaning, and draws the consequence that there is no value-free relation:

“There is no contact or relationship devoid of value.”

— KD, p. 20

KD also states that presence is itself fundamental distinctiveness, value, and meaning, and that the complete meaning of any meaning is realisation (KD, p. 23). Value, meaning, and distinctiveness are three names for one feature of a unit’s being present in coexistence. This is why the darshan can speak of the value of soil, of a medicine, of a relationship, and of *jeevan* without equivocation: in each case it names what that unit distinctively contributes to the order it belongs to.

1.2 Value as participation in orderliness

Essentiality answers what value is for a unit. Participation answers what value amounts to at the human level. The darshan’s summary formula for humaneness is orderliness with human-ness together with participation in the overall orderliness (MVD, p. 15). Human value is therefore not a private state but a place occupied in a widening order — self, family, society, and universal orderliness.

The practical sequence is stated as a chain: from sociality comes need; from need come use and production; from use and production comes earning; and from earning come use and right-use (MVD, p. 55). Sociality itself is defined by value-fulfilment:

“Sociality (samajikta): - Fulfilling the values inherent in relationships and associations itself is sociality.”

— MVD, p. 56

Two things follow. First, value-talk in this darshan is never merely evaluative commentary on conduct; it is the description of what a relationship is *for*. Second, human value cannot be assessed in isolation from participation, which is why the five dimensions of social orderliness — education–*sanskara*, justice–preservation, health–restraint, production–work, exchange–storage — appear in the darshan as the machinery of value-fulfilment rather than as optional institutions ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.15).

1.3 The five classes of value

Jeevan Vidya names the classes of value that a human being has to comprehend, and states where each resides:

“By comprehending human values, jeevan values, established values, and civic values, concerns about profit and loss vanish.”

— JV, p. 43

“Object value is spread everywhere, while jeevan values, human values, and established values are inherent to jeevan, and jeevan itself performs their evaluation.”

— JV, p. 139

Together these give a five-class taxonomy with a definite division of location.

Class	Bearer	What it is	How it is recognised	Evidence of fulfilment
Object value (<i>vastu mulya</i>)	Every insentient and pranic unit; produced goods	Usefulness of the unit for a purpose, with aesthetic value added in produced things	Evaluation of usefulness in use and production	Right-use; the object serving its purpose without waste
Jeevan values	<i>Jeevan</i>	Happiness, peace, contentment, bliss as harmonies among the faculties	Experienced directly by <i>jeevan</i> in its own activity	Continuity of harmony without self-contradiction
Human values (<i>manav mulya</i>)	The human being as such	The <i>dharma</i> and essential nature of being human: happiness, and fortitude, courage, generosity, kindness, grace, compassion	Understanding of <i>jeevan</i> and humane conduct	Humaneness in behaviour, work, and participation
Established values (<i>sthapit mulya</i>)	Relationship between humans	The values inherent in a recognised relationship — trust, respect, affection and the rest	Recognition of the relationship and its purpose	Fulfilment of the relationship’s inherent expectation; mutual satisfaction
Civic values	The human being as participant in orderliness	Values borne in association, system, and public life	Recognition of one’s place in the widening order	Participation in the five social dimensions; undivided society

The division of location is the load-bearing part. Object value is “spread everywhere” and does not depend on anyone’s *jeevan*; the other four are inherent to *jeevan* and are evaluated by *jeevan* without external instrument. JV emphasises that this evaluation needs no apparatus: it is examining the self, by the self, and for the self (JV, p. 139). The darshan therefore has an internalist account of how the high-

est values are known and an externalist account of how object value is known — and it does not attempt to run one method over both.

1.4 The four *jeevan* values as harmonies

The four *jeevan* values are defined structurally, as harmonies between adjacent faculties, not as pleasant sensations of varying intensity:

“Among the values, jeevan values are known by the names - happiness, peace, contentment and bliss, which are only names of the state of harmony within jeevan.”

— JV, p. 138

<i>Jeevan</i> value	Harmony between	Evidenced socially as
Happiness (<i>sukh</i>)	<i>mun</i> and <i>vritti</i>	Resolution in the individual
Peace (<i>shanti</i>)	<i>vritti</i> and <i>chitta</i>	Resolution with prosperity in the family
Contentment (<i>santosh</i>)	<i>chitta</i> and <i>buddhi</i>	Fearlessness through participation in society
Bliss (<i>anand</i>)	<i>buddhi</i> and <i>atma</i>	Coexistence, and the communication of understanding

Two consequences matter for value theory. First, because each value names a distinct harmony between a distinct pair of faculties, no amount of one can constitute another. A person may have abundant sensory satisfaction and no peace; the darshan’s own gloss is that sensory satisfaction does not necessarily lead to the heart’s satisfaction, though the reverse does hold (MVD, p. 67). Value is therefore structurally non-substitutable: MD has no single maximand and could not acquire one without abandoning the account of *jeevan*. Second, these values are not produced by acquisition. MVD defines contentment as “the lack of the sentiment of lacking” (MVD, p. 331) — an absence of deficiency-sentiment, not an accumulated quantity.

The harmonies also stand in a definite relation to the four human goals. Resolution is evidenced as happiness; peace becomes evident with resolution and prosperity in family living; contentment through orderly participation in society; and bliss in the course of living and communicating understanding ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.15). Inner value and outward condition are two readings of one achievement, which is why the darshan refuses both a purely private account of well-being and a purely institutional one.

1.5 Human values: the *dharma* and essential nature of the human being

Human value is stated as a *dharma* together with an essential nature:

“The Dharma of humans is happiness, and their essential nature is fortitude, courage, generosity, kindness, grace and compassion.”

— MVD, p. 125

MVD adds the identity “Sentiment = Essentiality” on the same page, and defines essential nature as the value of self with reflective sentiment (MVD, p. 124). Human value is thus not a code imposed on human beings; it is what a human being innately is, expressed as disposition.

The six terms of essential nature are separately defined, and three of them are distinguished by a criterion that is easy to miss — whether the recipient lacks the resource, the receptivity, or both.

Term	Definition	Distinguishing condition
Fortitude (<i>dhirata</i>)	Steadiness in the awakened human’s own conduct	—
Courage (<i>virata</i>)	Readiness to act on understanding despite resistance	—
Generosity (<i>udarta</i>)	Offering body, mind, and wealth as per need for another’s awakening, health, and prosperity, and experiencing happiness thereby (MVD, p. 340)	—
Kindness (<i>daya</i>)	The endeavour of making content available to those who have receptivity but lack the content (MVD, p. 61)	Receptivity present, content absent
Grace (<i>kripa</i>)	The endeavour of instilling receptivity in those for whom content is available but receptivity or humane perspective is lacking (MVD, p. 61)	Content present, receptivity absent
Compassion (<i>karuna</i>)	The endeavour of making both available to those who have neither (MVD, p. 61)	Both absent

This is characteristic of the darshan’s method: what other traditions treat as gradations of warmth are here separated by the objective condition of the person one is acting toward. The distinction matters axiologically because it makes these dispositions answerable to a fact about the situation rather than to the intensity of the agent’s feeling. MVD elsewhere compresses all three into love, defined as the combined expression of kindness, grace, and compassion (MVD, p. 331).

1.6 Established values in relationship

The established values are the values inherent in relationships. JV gives the list:

“Values such as care, guidance, trust, affection, gratitude, glory, love, reverence, and respect form the basis of our interactions.”
— JV, p. 108

The same passage adds that all relationships — the seven relationships — have continuity when values are realised within them, and that relationships without values lack continuity (JV, p. 108). MVD’s appendix defines each of the nine.

Established value	MVD definition	Cited
Care (<i>mamta</i>)	The act of nurturing and protecting with the pinnacle of affinity; the acceptance of the other as an image of oneself, and its continuity	MVD, p. 339
Guidance (<i>vatsalya</i>)	The continuity of nurturing and protection for comprehensive resolution	MVD, p. 332
Trust (<i>vishwas</i>)	The act of fulfilling the inherent expectation of values in mutuality; fulfilment of values inherent in mutuality	MVD, pp. 73, 336
Affection (<i>sneha</i>)	Absence of resistance in just behaviour; wilful meeting in, by, and for satisfaction, and its continuity	MVD, pp. 73, 340
Gratitude (<i>kritagyata</i>)	Acceptance of inspiration and support for the purpose of advancement and awakening	MVD, pp. 37, 335
Glory (<i>gaurav</i>)	Emulation, endeavour, and tendency embraced without resistance	MVD, pp. 37, 335
Love (<i>prem</i>)	Realisation of the complete; the combined expression of kindness, grace, and compassion	MVD, pp. 317, 331
Reverence (<i>shraddha</i>)	Movement towards righteousness, that is, qualitative transformation towards conduct completeness	MVD, pp. 326, 332
Respect (<i>samman</i>)	The acceptance of personality and talent, and its balanced exposition	MVD, p. 340

Three features of this list bear on the theory rather than on the individual values. First, none of the definitions is affective. Each names an activity, an acceptance, or a movement whose success conditions lie in the relationship rather than in the agent's inner warmth. Trust in particular is defined as *fulfilment*, not as confidence — a striking departure from most philosophical treatments of trust as an attitude under uncertainty.

Second, the values are not to be acquired from outside. JV states that values are inherent in *jeevan* and are deployed when relationships are recognised, using the case of a mother who needs no plan to feel care once she has recognised her child (JV, p. 138). The corresponding claim about failure is equally strong: where relationships are not recognised, there is no flow of values (JV, p. 55).

Third, the values are ordered by dependence rather than merely listed. JV says gratitude comes first, and that with gratitude the other values begin to manifest (JV, p. 108). MVD states the sequence as a chain:

“Gratitude leads to glory, glory leads to simplicity, simplicity leads to effortlessness, effortlessness leads to humaneness, humaneness leads to coexistence, and gratitude arises in, by, and for coexistence.”

— MVD, p. 38

The chain closes on itself: gratitude both begins the sequence and arises from coexistence, which is the sequence’s terminus. This is not a derivation of values from a first value. It is the claim that the value-structure is a cycle sustained by realisation, which is why the darshan treats value education as continuous rather than foundational.

1.7 Recognition, fulfilment, evaluation, mutual satisfaction

Values are recognised, not created. JV states the condition plainly:

“Values are realised through the recognition of relationships.”

— JV, p. 55

The full activity has four steps, and MVD’s appendix gives them as the definition of justice (*nyaya*), alongside its other gloss of justice as the acts carried out for nurturing, growth, and evaluation of humaneness:

“Recognition of relationships, Fulfilling of values, Evaluation, and Mutual satisfaction.”

— MVD, p. 336

SB gives the same sequence and identifies it with awakening rather than with rule-following: justice in humans, as the activities of recognising relationships, fulfilling values, and evaluating, is itself awakening (SB, p. 114). SB also lists the ability to recognise relationships, fulfil values, and perform evaluation among the attributes universally accessible to human beings (SB, pp. 122, 134).

Each step can fail independently, and the darshan’s account of moral failure is built from those independent failures rather than from weakness of will. A person may fail to recognise that a relationship is present; may recognise it and lack the capacity, ability, or receptivity to fulfil it; may fulfil it and evaluate the result wrongly; or may achieve satisfaction on one side only. [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §1.5 traces the same sequence from the side of knowing. What this study adds is that *mutual* satisfaction, not satisfaction, is the terminus. One-sided satisfaction does not complete the sequence, which is what blocks a preference-satisfaction reading of the darshan’s axiology.

1.8 Evaluation as sentiment activity

Evaluation has a technical name and a technical location. MVD assigns values and evaluation together to *bhav-kriya*, and makes their correctness depend on the evaluator:

“The process of values and evaluation is referred to as the ‘sentiment activity’, which operates by distinguishing between real and unreal, based on the evaluator’s state of awakening or delusion.”

— MVD, p. 203

The glossary confirms the identification of the term itself: sentiment (*bhav*) is glossed simply as “Value, evaluation” (MVD, p. 326). Value and evaluation are thus not two subject matters but one activity considered as content and as act.

Correctness then has a single stated condition and three named failures:

“The correct evaluation occurs only through awakening with complete understanding; otherwise, under-evaluation, over-evaluation or mis-evaluation takes place.”

— MVD, p. 203

SB states the same triad as the manifestation of delusion (SB, p. 146). Three further terms are defined against it. Conceit (*abhimān*) is *imposed* evaluation, characterised by the flaws of over-evaluation, under-evaluation, or mis-evaluation (MVD, pp. 38, 185). Attachment (*asakti*) is believing mistakes made towards decline to be correct (MVD, p. 124). Dispassion is defined negatively and precisely:

“Dispassion means freedom from attachment, which is being without the flaws of over-evaluation, under-evaluation and mis-evaluation.”

— MVD, p. 152

This gives the darshan an unusual account of a familiar virtue. Dispassion is not indifference to value; it is evaluative accuracy. The same logic makes self-evaluation the entry point rather than an advanced exercise:

“Therefore, self-evaluation is the first and foremost step for humans from the point of view of their own development.”

— MVD, p. 87

Object value has its own evaluative acts, defined with the same economy: embracing (*grihan*) is the evaluation of usefulness, and discarding (*visarjan*) the assessment that something is not useful (MVD, p. 84).

1.9 The rooting chain

MVD states the dependencies among value, evaluation, and language as a chain that returns to its beginning:

“Language has sentiment (bhav) at its root; sentiment has essentiality at its root; essentiality has evaluation at its root; evaluation has worldview at its root; worldview has perceiver at its root; perceiver has capacity, ability and receptivity at its root; capacity, ability and receptivity have the perception, comprehension and awareness of truth at its root; perception, comprehension and awareness of truth have the language at its root.”

— MVD, p. 83

The passage closes by naming all of these as activities of *chitta*, which succeed or fail according to the perceiver’s level of awakening. Read as a linear justification the chain is circular: language is grounded in sentiment, and awareness of truth — on which sentiment ultimately rests — is grounded in language. Read as the darshan appears to intend it, the chain is a description of one integrated activity in which no member operates alone, and the variable that determines whether the whole functions is awakening rather than the ordering of the members.

That reading is available in the text, and it is consistent with the general claim that in the absence of awareness there is no determination of value, presence, or fundamental distinctiveness (KD, p. 23). It nevertheless leaves the darshan without a non-circular route from a disputed evaluation to its correction, which is taken up in §7.2.

1.10 The six perspectives as a value ordering

Human behaviour is expressed through six evaluative perspectives:

“All human behaviour is manifest in six perspectives: - (1) pleasant-unpleasant, (2) healthy-unhealthy, (3) profit-loss, (4) justice-injustice, (5) dharma-adharma, and (6) truth-untruth.”

— MVD, p. 67

MVD assigns the first three to the inhumane perspective and the last three to the humane perspective (MVD, pp. 58, 60), and adds a seventh standpoint above both: the higher-humane perspective is “Only Truth” (MVD, p. 61). [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.12 sets out the perspectives and their domains; the question for axiology is what kind of ordering this is.

Three readings are possible. On a *lexical priority* reading, no gain in pleasure, health, or profit could ever offset a loss in justice, *dharma*, or truth. On a *domain partition* reading, each perspective is authoritative in its own domain and the classification simply records which questions each can settle. On a *grounding* reading, the humane perspectives supply the standard by which the first three are correctly used, so the lower three are not rivals but subordinate instruments.

The texts support the third with an element of the second. MVD does not reject pleasure, health, or profit; it denies their sufficiency as an organising standpoint, and calls the behaviour of humans with inhumane perspective the behaviour that takes refuge in them (MVD, p. 58). The complementary chain runs law to justice, justice to *dharma*, *dharma* to truth, truth to coexistence, and realisation in coexistence to bliss — a widening of the field of evaluation rather than a scale of magnitudes. A strict

lexical reading would be too strong for the texts, since the darshan expects the lower perspectives to be satisfied rather than sacrificed; a pure partition reading would be too weak, since it could not explain why an evaluation made only in profit-and-loss terms counts as mistaken rather than merely partial.

1.11 Higher and lower value

Alongside the classification of perspectives, the darshan uses a comparative vocabulary of higher and lower value. Its anchor is a definition of profit that inverts the usual one:

“Obtaining a higher value in exchange for a lower value is profit.”

— MVD, p. 67

And immediately after, the conditions under which the reverse occurs:

“Higher value is offered in exchange for a lower value in three situations: (1) due to helplessness, (2) willingly, and (3) due to ignorance.”

— MVD, p. 67

MVD supplies the content of the comparison on the next page but one: resolved outlook is called higher value, and tendency for problems lower value (MVD, p. 126). The pair is therefore not a ranking of goods by desirability. It ranks states of a unit or a relationship by whether they tend towards resolution or towards problems, and the dynamics are given their own terms.

Term	Definition	Cited
Mutual ascent (<i>ubhaya sukruti</i>)	Movement towards attaining higher value and long-lasting result or permanence, and awakening	MVD, pp. 44, 110
Mutual descent (<i>ubhaya vikruti</i>)	Movement towards lower value or short-lasting result and decline	MVD, p. 110
Inspiration (<i>prerna</i>)	Movement towards mutual ascent upon coming together	MVD, p. 110
Retrogression (<i>pratikranti</i>)	Movement towards mutual descent upon coming together	MVD, p. 110
Ascension cause	Progress from lower-value to higher-value result, maturation, and consequence	MVD, p. 219
Descension cause	Movement from higher-value to lower-value result, maturation, and consequence	MVD, p. 219

Two features are distinctive. First, durability is built into the comparison: higher value is paired with long-lasting or non-transformable result, lower value with short-lasting result. What makes a value higher is not intensity but stability under continuation — a criterion the darshan can apply without ap-

peeling to anyone's preference. Second, the ordering is claimed to be motivationally effective on its own:

"It is natural for a lower value to be attracted towards a higher value."

— MVD, p. 222

The corresponding social claim is that a successful society keeps environment, opportunity, and means available for that attraction to operate (MVD, p. 222), and that acceptance of higher value through followership succeeds only where the higher value is genuine (MVD, p. 220). This is where the darshan locates the mechanism of value transmission: not in sanction, but in the availability of realised higher value for emulation — which is also the definition of glory in §1.6.

1.12 Object value: usefulness, aesthetic addition, and symbol

Object value is treated as a distinct class with distinct behaviour. JV states its constancy:

"The object value remains constant. For example, whatever value (usefulness) is there in one kilogram sesame seeds, it has always been the same. Similarly, the value of medicine, rice, wheat, vegetables, etc also remains constant. This is called usefulness value."

— JV, p. 137

The same passage adds a second kind for produced things: in cars, trains, and the like, aesthetic value gets added, and aesthetics is meaningful when it adds convenience to usefulness (JV, pp. 137–138). Aesthetics is thus not an autonomous value domain in this darshan but a qualification of usefulness; [Aesthetics](#) §4.1 develops the point.

Against these two stands a third kind, which the darshan treats as the characteristic error of economic life:

"The accumulation is only of money, which is symbolic value."

— MVD, p. 183

Kind of object value	What it tracks	Status in the darshan
Usefulness value (<i>upyogita mulya</i>)	What the object can do for a human purpose	Constant; the real value of the object
Aesthetic value	Convenience added to usefulness in produced things	Genuine when it serves usefulness; distorting when it inflates desire
Symbolic value (<i>prateek mulya</i>)	Money as a token of exchange	Not a value of any object; accumulable, and therefore the site of the profit-and-loss cycle

JV draws the political conclusion directly. Humans allocated value to everything where profit could be made while neglecting the value of humanity, and the profit-and-loss cycle is one that neither communism nor capitalism escaped — communism ending in the pursuit of national profit, capitalism prioritising profit openly (JV, p. 43). The darshan’s alternative is to live on the basis of usefulness value. SB adds the ecological application: evaluation of natural treasure is to be performed on the basis of its usefulness, with use and right-use in proportion to regeneration (SB, p. 141). This study takes those claims only as far as the kinds of value require; production, exchange, and accumulation belong to *Prosperity Economics and Right Use*.

1.13 What makes an evaluation correct

The darshan holds both that value is objective and that evaluation is correct only under awakening. Read carelessly, the pair looks inconsistent. The texts resolve it by making the *standard* of evaluation the essentiality of the thing evaluated, and awakening the *condition* under which that standard is accessible.

SB states the standard for the human case:

“The natural state refers to the essentiality of humans, i.e. human-ness. It is on this basis alone that humans could be rightly evaluated.”

— SB, p. 201

The same chapter says that in humane living, human essentiality itself becomes the basis of evaluation (SB, p. 200). KD gives the general version: only on the basis of fundamental distinctiveness does the evaluation of values come to be (KD, p. 67). Since essentiality is value (§1.1), correct evaluation is recognition of what the unit already is, and the three failure modes of §1.8 are three ways of misdescribing it — assigning more than the essentiality warrants, less, or something other.

The condition is stated with equal firmness. SB holds that values and existence, or essential nature and *dharma*, are recognised only through *jeevan*, and that humans express, communicate, and evaluate values only upon awakening (SB, p. 64). SB also separates the two orders of activity that this makes possible: eating and sleeping serve the body’s needs, while values and evaluation serve *jeevan*’s purpose (SB, p. 92).

This is Madhyasth Darshan’s answer to the question that motivates much of modern metaethics. Value is not derived from a preference, nor from a command, nor from a non-natural property; it is what a unit essentially is, and evaluation is a cognitive achievement about a real subject matter. Whether the darshan can show that the achievement has been reached in any particular case is a separate question, taken up in §7.

1.14 Value, character, and ethics

Humane conduct is presented as a compound of three things, with value first:

“In this way, humane conduct is explained as the combined form of values, character, and ethics.”

— JV, p. 55

KD gives the same formula and adds that only on the basis of fundamental distinctiveness does the evaluation of values come to be (KD, p. 67). JV specifies the other two members concretely: character is rightfully owned wealth, marital faithfulness, and kindness in work and behaviour; ethics is the right-use and protection of resources in the form of body, mind, and wealth (JV, p. 55).

The ordering is doctrinally significant. In this darshan axiology is not a branch of ethics but its presupposition: character and ethics are what value-fulfilment looks like in disposition and in the handling of resources. *Ethics and Morals in Human Beings* develops character and right-use; what belongs here is the structural point that the darshan cannot treat “what is valuable” as a question settled by ethical theory, because its ethics is already specified in terms of values recognised in relationships.

1.15 Value, deliberation, and result

Value determination is assigned to a specific activity of *jeevan*. KD states that the determination of practical values occurs only through deliberation, and that practical values become meaningful in the sense of humaneness (KD, p. 16). Taste, the activity of *mun*, is what savours value once it is fulfilled: it is when the taste activity starts having fulfilment of values that those values are given names such as love, trust, affection, gratitude, and guidance (JV, p. 138). MVD’s appendix organises this vocabulary systematically, enumerating two activities of *atma*, four of *buddhi*, sixteen of *chitta*, thirty-six of *vritti*, and sixty-four of *mun* (MVD, pp. 328, 329, 332, 339), each defined as a value or a state. The darshan’s value vocabulary is thus not a list of virtues appended to a psychology; it is the expansion of the ten activities of *jeevan* into their named expressions.

KD also places value in a derivation sequence from desire to evidence: by the distinction of desire comes investigation, by that the destination, by that realisation, and by the distinction of realisation comes value (KD, p. 4). Value is therefore downstream of realisation and upstream of evidence, and it is answerable to result. KD’s insistence that practical value is itself stable value (KD, p. 20) blocks a purely contemplative axiology: a value that never becomes practical is not thereby a higher value but an unfulfilled one. Self-value is given the same practical gloss — self-value alone is the satisfaction of activity and cessation (KD, p. 46).

The recurrent structure is completed by evaluation of result. Karma has result; result returns to the knower through evaluation; and repeated action and evaluation shape *sanskar*, which conditions later projection ([The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §1.7). Values are corrigible in practice even though the darshan holds value itself to be objective, because what gets corrected is the evaluation, not the value.

1.16 Value across the four orders

Since value is the essentiality of any unit, the material, pranic, and animal orders have value in full measure. What they lack is evaluation. The first three orders recognise and fulfil through structural, seed, or species conformance, and their orderliness does not depend on reflective choice; the knowl-

edge order must add knowing and believing before action and explicit evaluation after it ([The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §1.5).

This yields a position with few close analogues. Value is objective and universally distributed; evaluation is a knowledge-order activity performed by *jeevan* alone; and the human being is therefore uniquely responsible without being the source of value. SB's application is that under delusion humans exploit the nature other than humans, while upon realisation of seer-status they appear as nurturers (SB, p. 200). Right-use follows from the objectivity of value rather than from a calculation of human interest — a difference from most environmental ethics, where the value of nature has to be argued for either as instrumental to human welfare or as an extension of moral standing.

1.17 Method, evidence, and what Madhyasth Darshan establishes

The axiological claims do not all warrant the same kind of assent, and separating them is necessary before comparison.

Some are **definitional within the system**: essentiality is value (SB, p. 50); sentiment is value and evaluation (MVD, p. 326); justice is the four-step sequence (MVD, p. 336); humane conduct is value, character, and ethics (JV, p. 55). These can be assessed for coherence and fruitfulness, not for truth against external evidence.

Some are **structural claims about human beings** that could in principle be checked: that the four *jeevan* values are non-substitutable; that values flow on recognition of relationship rather than being imported; that only four and a half of *jeevan*'s ten activities function under delusion. These make predictions about what people report and how they act, and partial evidence for the first is examined in §4.3.

Some are **claims about the correctness of evaluation** — that awakening with complete understanding yields correct evaluation, and that its absence yields over-, under-, or mis-evaluation. These are the darshan's strongest axiological commitments and its least publicly testable, because the criterion of correct evaluation and the criterion of awakening are given in terms of each other.

Some are **social and economic claims**: that usefulness value is constant; that money is symbolic value only; that the profit-and-loss cycle is escapable by living on usefulness value. These are empirical and are the most exposed to counter-evidence (§7.5).

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

Advaita Vedanta holds that value in the ordinary sense belongs to the empirical order and is finally superseded. What is unconditionally valuable is not an object, a relationship, or a state of affairs but the Self, which is already of the nature of bliss. The tradition therefore has a rich account of values as qualification and as expression, and a principled reason for denying that anything in the world is valuable in its own right.

2.1 The *purusharthas* and their ordering

Classical Vedanta inherits the fourfold scheme of human ends — *dharma*, *artha*, *kama*, and *moksha* — and ranks *moksha* as the *parama-purushartha*, the end beyond which nothing is sought. The first three are legitimate within the empirical order and are ordered among themselves, with *dharma* regulating the pursuit of wealth and pleasure. The decisive Advaitic move is not the ranking but the difference in kind: *artha* and *kama* are attained and lost, *dharma* produces results within time, while *moksha* is not produced at all. Shankara's *Brahma Sutra Bhashya* treats liberation as eternally accomplished and merely obscured by ignorance, so the highest value is not a state to be brought about but a fact to be recognised.

2.2 *Ananda* as nature, not attainment

Brahman is characterised as Existence, Consciousness, and Bliss. In the Taittiriya Upanishad's ascent through the sheaths, *ananda* appears as the innermost, and Shankara reads bliss not as an intense pleasure but as the absence of the limitation that makes pleasure episodic. The *Vivekachudamani*, a later pedagogical witness, states the same identification (v. 152).

The axiological consequence is far-reaching. If the highest value is one's own nature, then no action can produce it and no loss can remove it. Value-seeking, on this account, is structurally mistaken about its own object: what is sought as an outcome is already the seeker. The tradition's positive teaching about happiness is therefore diagnostic rather than prescriptive.

2.3 The Maitreyi passage

The sharpest axiological statement in the corpus is Yajnavalkya's teaching to Maitreyi in the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad (2.4.5): the husband is not dear for the sake of the husband, nor wealth for the sake of wealth, but everything is dear for the sake of the Self. Dearness (*priyata*) has a single source, and its apparent distribution across persons and things is a misattribution.

This is a genuine theory of value, not a devotional flourish. It explains why particular attachments feel unconditional and why they nonetheless disappoint, and it grounds an argument for renunciation that does not depend on calling the world evil. It also marks the deepest divergence from Madhyasth Darshan, which holds that value is distributed among units and that each relationship has its own inherent expectation to fulfil. For Advaita, the plurality of values is a refracted appearance of one value; for Madhyasth Darshan, plurality is real and the four *jeevan* harmonies are irreducibly four.

2.4 Values as qualification

Advaita is exacting about the values a seeker must already have. The *sadhana-chatushtaya* comprises discrimination between the eternal and the non-eternal (*viveka*), dispassion (*vairagya*), the six treasures beginning with tranquillity and self-restraint, and the intense desire for liberation (*mumukshutva*). The *Vivekachudamani* sets out these qualifications and the virtues that support them (vv. 17–20, 69, 82); the Bhagavad Gita's list of divine qualities — non-injury, truthfulness, absence of anger, renunciation, kindness, purity — serves the same function (16.2–16.3).

These are values in a specific role: they qualify a person for knowledge without themselves constituting the goal. Dispassion in particular is instructive to compare. In Advaita, *vairagya* is turning away from what is non-eternal; in Madhyasth Darshan, dispassion is freedom from the three flaws of evaluation (MVD, p. 152). Both refuse to identify it with indifference, but one defines it by withdrawal and the other by accuracy.

2.5 Action, result, and *loka-sangraha*

The Gita supplies Advaita's practical axiology. Prescribed action is to be performed without attachment to its fruit (3.8), and the enlightened continue to act for the holding-together of the world (3.20, 3.25–26). Shankara reads such action as neither productive of liberation nor obstructive of it.

This yields a stable but thin account of relational value. Conduct matters, and the *jivanmukta*'s conduct is exemplary; but its value is not that a relationship's inherent expectation has been met, since at the level of final truth there are no relata. The tradition's own vocabulary for the world's holding-together is enough to sustain a practical ethics and not enough to ground the value of the world as such.

2.6 Method, evidence, and what Advaita establishes

Advaita's method is *sruti* as the means of knowledge for what is beyond perception and inference, supported by reasoning and by the discipline of hearing, reflection, and sustained contemplation (BU 2.4.5). Its axiological achievements are two. It establishes, with unusual rigour, that a value which can be gained and lost cannot be the final good, and it offers a unified explanation of why finite goods disappoint. What it does not establish, by its own lights, is that the plurality of values in the empirical order is anything other than provisional — and this is a consequence its tradition accepts rather than a gap it seeks to close.

3. Modern Western Axiology and Metaethics

Modern Western philosophy has no single answer about value; it has a well-mapped space of positions and a set of arguments that constrain them. The relevant contrast with the other two traditions is not a doctrine but a method: Western value theory has largely proceeded by isolating questions — Is value objective? Is it reducible to natural facts? Is it one thing or many? — and pursuing each independently.

3.1 Intrinsic, final, and instrumental value

The organising distinction is between what is valuable as a means and what is valuable in itself. Moore's *Principia Ethica* proposed the isolation test: to determine whether something has intrinsic value, imagine it existing alone and ask whether its existence would be good. Later work separated two things Moore ran together — being valuable *for its own sake* (final value) and being valuable *in virtue of intrinsic properties* — since something may be finally valuable partly because of its history or relations. Moore's own doctrine of organic unities already conceded that the value of a whole need not be the sum of the values of its parts.

Two points of contact with §1.1 are worth marking. Madhyasth Darshan's identification of value with essentiality resembles a claim about intrinsic value in the second sense, since essentiality is what the unit is. But the darshan also holds that value is what is reciprocated in mutuality (SB, p. 50), which makes it relational in a way the isolation test would not register. And the darshan has no use for the summing of values that organic unities are introduced to correct, because its values are not quantities.

3.2 The is–ought gap and the open question

Hume's observation in the *Treatise* that writers pass from *is* to *ought* without explaining the transition set the modern problem. Moore's open question argument sharpened it: for any proposed natural analysis of goodness — the pleasant, the desired, the more evolved — it remains an open question whether what satisfies the analysis is good, which suggests that the analysis has not captured the concept.

Madhyasth Darshan does not answer these arguments in their own terms; it declines the framing that generates them. If essentiality is value, there is no inference from *is* to *ought* to justify, because the evaluative fact is not a further fact. Whether that is a solution or a redescription is the question raised in §7.4. What can be said here is that the move is not unfamiliar: neo-Aristotelian naturalism makes a structurally similar claim by grounding goodness in the characteristic form of a kind of living thing.

3.3 Realism, constructivism, and expressivism

The main metaethical families can be arranged by what they say about the truth of value judgments. Naturalist realism identifies value properties with natural ones; non-naturalist realism accepts irreducible normative facts; constructivism grounds normative truth in the standpoint of agents or in procedures of practical reason; expressivism and quasi-realism treat value judgments as expressions of attitude that nonetheless support the trappings of truth-talk; error theory holds that value judgments purport to describe objective values and fail. Each family carries a characteristic cost: reduction risks the open question, non-naturalism risks epistemic mystery, constructivism risks losing the mind-independence it set out to explain, expressivism risks the loss of disagreement, and error theory the loss of the practice.

Madhyasth Darshan is closest in outcome to a naturalist realism, but it is not a reduction of value to properties describable by the natural sciences. Its natural order includes *jeevan*, essentiality, and *dharma*, none of which is a physical quantity, and its epistemology of value is the knowledge-order activity of a sentient unit rather than perception or inference from measurement. In the Western taxonomy it is best described as a realism whose ontology is not physicalist — a position the taxonomy accommodates but rarely occupies.

3.4 Fitting-attitude accounts, reasons, and response-dependence

An influential family analyses value in terms of the attitudes it would be fitting to take: to be valuable is to be a fitting object of pro-attitudes. Scanlon's buck-passing variant holds that being valuable is not itself a reason-giving property but a way of indicating that other properties provide reasons. Response-dependent accounts make value constitutively connected to idealised human responses.

This is the nearest Western analogue to *bhav-kriya*, and the comparison is instructive because the direction of dependence differs. On fitting-attitude accounts, the fittingness of the attitude is what value consists in. In Madhyasth Darshan, value consists in essentiality, and the attitude — sentiment, evaluation, taste — either tracks it or fails to. The darshan can therefore say that an entire tradition evaluates wrongly, which fitting-attitude accounts can say only by idealising the responses far enough to raise the question of what makes the idealisation correct.

3.5 Theories of well-being

The theories of what makes a life go well divide into hedonism, desire-satisfaction views, and objective-list or perfectionist views. Nozick's experience machine is the standard objection to hedonism: most people judge that a life of pleasant experience disconnected from reality goes worse, which suggests that something other than experiential quality matters. Desire-satisfaction views face the problem of ill-informed, adaptive, and self-destructive desires; objective lists face the charge of being unmotivated unless the items are tied to something about the person. Parfit's taxonomy and his discussion of "global" preferences remain the reference points.

Madhyasth Darshan's four harmonies function as an objective list with an unusual structural warrant: the items are not selected as plausibly good but read off the relations among *jeevan*'s faculties. Whether that warrant can be checked independently is a separate matter; what it does secure is an answer to the standard objection to objective lists, since the items are tied to the constitution of the subject whose life is at issue.

3.6 Pluralism, incommensurability, dignity, and price

Berlin argued that fundamental values genuinely conflict and that some losses cannot be compensated. Raz developed incommensurability as the failure of the comparative relations that a single scale would require, and Chang's work distinguishes several ways comparison can break down. Anderson's expressive theory holds that different goods call for different modes of valuation, so treating a good in the wrong mode is itself a failure. Kant's distinction between dignity and price is the classical version: what has dignity admits of no equivalent, and to price it is a category error rather than an undervaluation.

The convergences here are the strongest in this comparison. The darshan's non-substitutable *jeevan* values are a claim of incommensurability, and its treatment of money as symbolic value that cannot represent the value of anything (MVD, p. 183) is close to Kant's point about price. The divergence is that Western pluralism generally treats incommensurability as a source of tragic and rationally unresolvable conflict, whereas Madhyasth Darshan treats it as a feature of a fundamentally harmonious order, in which apparent conflicts among genuine values indicate an error of evaluation rather than a limit of practical reason.

3.7 Material value-ethics: Scheler and Hartmann

Max Scheler's *Formalism in Ethics and Non-Formal Ethics of Values* is the closest structural counterpart to Madhyasth Darshan's axiology in modern Western thought, and the resemblance goes beyond

terminology. Scheler holds that values are objective qualities, not projections; that they are grasped not by reason or by sense but by *Wertfühlen*, an intentional feeling with its own cognitive adequacy; that values fall into an ordered hierarchy — sensory, vital, spiritual, and religious; and that the hierarchy is discovered rather than posited, with the height of a value indexed to its endurance and its independence of the body. He also gives a systematic account of evaluative error, including *Wertverblendung*, value-blindness, and *ressentiment*, in which the ranking is inverted rather than merely misapplied.

Nicolai Hartmann's *Ethics* develops the same programme with more attention to the criteria of height and to the tension between a value's height and its urgency — a distinction Scheler underplays and which the darshan's pairing of higher value with durability partly parallels.

The points of contact with §§1.8 and 1.11 are exact enough to be worth listing. Both treat value as objective and non-natural in the physicalist sense; both locate value-cognition in a non-inferential faculty distinct from perception and reasoning; both order values by rank rather than quantity, with durability as a mark of height; both build a theory of characteristic evaluative failure, and both regard entire cultures as capable of systematic value-inversion.

The differences are equally exact. Scheler's ranks are *a priori* essences given in feeling; the darshan's ranks derive from the participation of units in an orderly coexistence, so its account of why the ranking holds is ontological rather than phenomenological. Scheler's hierarchy culminates in the value of the holy; the darshan's culminates in coexistence and its realisation, and it has no category of the sacred to place at the top. And Scheler has no counterpart to the claim that correct evaluation requires an achieved transformation of the evaluator, which is where the darshan's axiology becomes inseparable from its account of awakening.

3.8 Economic value

Classical political economy separated use-value from exchange-value and sought the source of the latter in labour; Smith and Ricardo developed the labour theory that Marx then used to argue that exchange-value under capitalism systematically diverges from and dominates use-value, and that money functions as the universal equivalent in which qualitatively different goods are made commensurable. The marginalist revolution replaced this with subjective utility at the margin, and twentieth-century economics reduced utility further to a representation of consistent preference through revealed preference theory.

Sen's critique is the pivotal modern intervention: utility conflates well-being with preference satisfaction, ignores adaptation, and cannot register what a person is actually able to do. The capability approach, developed with Nussbaum's account of central capabilities, replaces utility with the substantive freedoms a person has.

The darshan's threefold division of object value in §1.12 maps onto this history in a way that is neither classical nor marginalist. Usefulness value is close to use-value and is asserted to be constant, which no economic tradition accepts. Symbolic value is close to Marx's universal equivalent, and MD's objection to it is the same in structure — that a token of exchange comes to be treated as the thing of

value — but the darshan's remedy is not the abolition of a mode of production; it is exchange organised through recognition of labour value with production oriented to assessed need.

3.9 Recognition, care, and trust

A final family locates value in relationship. Hegel's account of mutual recognition, developed by Honneth into a theory of recognition as the condition of self-realisation, holds that persons acquire practical standing only through being recognised by others. Care ethics takes the caring relation, rather than the autonomous agent, as the primary moral phenomenon. Philosophical work on trust treats it as a three-place attitude of dependence under vulnerability, with characteristic conditions of reasonableness and betrayal.

The overlap with §§1.6–1.7 is substantial, and one difference is decisive. In these Western accounts, recognition or care partly *constitutes* the value at stake — being recognised is what confers standing. In Madhyasth Darshan, recognition is the discovery of a value already inherent in the relationship, and the relationship's inherent expectation exists whether or not either party recognises it. This is why the darshan can hold that unrecognised relationships fail while denying that value is conferred by recognition, and why its account of trust is a claim about fulfilment rather than about the reasonableness of an attitude.

3.10 Method, evidence, and what philosophy establishes

Western value theory establishes distinctions and constraints rather than results. It has shown that value cannot be straightforwardly identified with pleasure, with desire-satisfaction, or with market price; that the passage from natural fact to evaluative conclusion needs an account; that some goods resist comparison on a single scale; and that treating a good in the wrong mode is a distinct kind of failure. It has not converged on the objectivity question, and its principal internal difficulty is that each family's answer to the epistemology of value inherits the problems of its metaphysics.

4. Modern Scientific Approaches

The sciences do not investigate value; they investigate valuation. That restriction is not a failing but a boundary, and keeping it visible is necessary if the convergences reported below are not to be over-read.

4.1 Valuation in the brain

Decision neuroscience has established that the brain computes something like a common currency. Dopaminergic activity in the midbrain encodes reward prediction error — the difference between received and expected reward — in a form well described by temporal-difference learning, and value signals correlating with subjective choice appear in ventromedial prefrontal and orbitofrontal cortex across widely different goods. Neuroeconomics reads these findings as evidence that heterogeneous options are converted into a comparable quantity before choice.

The result cuts two ways for axiology. It shows that the brain does something a single-scale theory of value predicts, which is a real difficulty for strong incommensurability claims. It equally shows that the quantity computed is a decision variable, not a measure of what is worth choosing: reward prediction error is defined against expectation, so the same objective outcome yields different signals depending on prior belief. Nothing in the neuroscience distinguishes valuing well from valuing badly.

4.2 Evolutionary accounts of valuing

Evolutionary biology explains why organisms value at all. Kin selection, reciprocal altruism, and the dynamics of repeated interaction account for cooperative dispositions without appeal to a moral faculty, and cross-cultural work has found that a small set of cooperative behaviours is positively valued across large samples of societies. Curry, Mullins, and Whitehouse's survey of sixty societies found no society in which cooperative behaviours were negatively valued.

Two interpretations of these findings compete. On the debunking reading, an evolutionary genealogy of our value judgments undercuts their claim to track anything beyond fitness. On the vindicating reading, cooperation is a real feature of social life and our capacity to recognise it is reliable for the same reason perception is. The evidence does not settle the choice, because the genealogy is compatible with both. What it does establish is that valuing is not culturally arbitrary — a conclusion that sits comfortably with the darshan's claim that human essentiality is universal, and equally comfortably with a purely naturalistic account of why it seems so.

4.3 Well-being science

Empirical well-being research has produced findings that bear directly on §1.4. Hedonic adaptation shows that many large changes in circumstance have transient effects on reported well-being. The Easterlin paradox — that within-country happiness has not risen with average income over long periods, even though richer individuals report higher happiness at a given time — remains contested but has not been dissolved. Kahneman and Deaton's separation of experienced from evaluative well-being found that emotional well-being ceases to rise with income above a threshold while life evaluation continues to rise, which is direct evidence that at least two distinct things are being measured under one name.

Self-determination theory is the closest empirical analogue to the darshan's structural claim. It posits three basic psychological needs — autonomy, competence, and relatedness — whose satisfaction predicts well-being, and holds that they are not interchangeable: high competence does not compensate for thwarted relatedness. A body of evidence also shows that extrinsic goals such as wealth and status are associated with lower well-being even when attained.

The convergence is real but partial and should be stated carefully. Empirical work supports the claim that well-being is not a single quantity and that its components are not mutually substitutable. It does not support the specific fourfold division of happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss, and it does not identify any component with a harmony between named faculties. The darshan's account is consistent with the findings without being confirmed by them.

4.4 Trust and prosociality as measured goods

Social science treats trust as a measurable variable with substantial economic consequences: generalised trust correlates with growth, institutional quality, and lower transaction costs, and behavioural game theory has established robust patterns of conditional cooperation and costly punishment that simple self-interest models do not predict. This supports the darshan's placing of trust at the centre of social value while measuring something different from what the darshan defines. Survey trust is an expectation about others; MVD's trust is the fulfilment of values inherent in mutuality (MVD, p. 336). The measured variable is closer to what the darshan would call the anticipation of fulfilment than to fulfilment itself.

4.5 Measurement, proxies, and their failure

Applied economics has documented the costs of measuring the wrong thing. GDP omits unpaid work, depletion of natural capital, and distribution; discount rates chosen for tractability determine conclusions about long-horizon harms; and preference-based welfare measures inherit whatever adaptation and misinformation shaped the preferences. The response has been a proliferation of alternative indices, none of which has displaced the original.

The persistence of this problem is independent evidence for a claim the darshan makes on other grounds: that a single scale imposed on plural values will misdirect the activity it is meant to guide.

4.6 Specification and alignment

The most recent independent evidence comes from machine learning. Goodhart's law — that a measure adopted as a target ceases to be a good measure — has been reproduced systematically in the study of reward hacking and specification gaming, where optimising systems reliably find policies that maximise a stated objective while defeating its purpose. Surveys of specification gaming catalogue dozens of instances, and the concrete-problems literature treats the difficulty of specifying objectives as a central obstacle rather than an engineering detail.

The structural lesson is exactly the one in §1.10: a proxy drawn from a lower evaluative domain, optimised without the standard that gives it its point, destroys the value it stood for. This is a convergence of some significance, since it arises from engineering practice with no philosophical commitments at all.

4.7 Method, evidence, and what science establishes

The sciences establish that valuation is a real, mechanistically describable process; that its outputs are systematically biased in ways we can measure; that well-being is not one quantity; that plural goods resist aggregation in practice as well as in theory; and that optimising proxies is dangerous. They do not establish what is valuable, and their methods are not constructed to. Where a scientific finding appears to settle an axiological question, the appearance normally comes from a value premise already built into the choice of measure.

5. Comparison

5.1 Criteria for comparison

The four positions are compared on eight questions: what value is; where value resides; how value is known; whether values are commensurable; the standing of pleasure; the treatment of economic value; the final aim; and how a mistaken evaluation is corrected. These are chosen because each tradition takes a definite position on all eight, which is not true of finer-grained questions.

5.2 Cross-tradition summary

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural and social sciences
What value is	The essentiality of a unit as it participates in coexistence	Finally, the Self as bliss; derivatively, what serves liberation	Contested: natural property, irreducible normative fact, construction, or attitude	Not addressed; valuation is a computed decision variable
Where value resides	In every unit; the higher classes inherent in <i>jeevan</i>	In the Self alone; apparent dearness in objects is misattributed	Varies by family: in objects, in attitudes, in agents' standpoints	In nervous systems and in populations of preferences
How value is known	By <i>jeevan</i> , through the sentiment activity, correctly only under awakening	By <i>sruti</i> with reflection and contemplation, culminating in realisation	By intuition, reflective equilibrium, idealised response, or nothing	By measurement of choice, report, and physiology
Commensurability	Non-substitutable classes; higher and lower ranks with durability as mark of height	Radical asymmetry between <i>moksha</i> and everything else	Plural and often incommensurable; some traditions retain a single scale	Common currency at the point of choice; no scale for worth
Standing of pleasure	Real and legitimate in its domain; insufficient as an organising standpoint	Non-eternal, and therefore not the good	Hedonism a live but minority position; the experience machine its standard problem	A measurable component of well-being, subject to adaptation

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural and social sciences
Economic value	Usefulness constant; money symbolic only; accumulation the characteristic error	Wealth a legitimate but subordinate end	Use-value against exchange-value; utility; capabilities	Preference-based, with documented measurement failures
Final aim	Resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, coexistence — with the four harmonies	<i>Moksha</i> , already accomplished and merely to be recognised	No consensus; well-being, virtue, or autonomy on different accounts	Outside the domain
Correcting evaluation	Awakening, self-evaluation, and evidence in result and mutual satisfaction	Removal of ignorance by knowledge; <i>sublation</i> of the lower by the higher	Argument, reflective equilibrium, and appeal to considered judgments	Replication, debiasing, and better instruments

5.3 Locus of value

The four positions divide most sharply on where value is. Madhyasth Darshan distributes value across all units and makes *jeevan* the evaluator, not the source. Advaita concentrates all value in the Self and treats its apparent distribution as error. Western philosophy is genuinely divided, and the division is what its metaethical debate is about. The sciences do not take a position, but their explanatory practice locates valuation in valuers, which functions as a default in favour of the view that value is conferred.

The consequence for relationships is the clearest test. Madhyasth Darshan holds that a relationship has an inherent expectation whether or not it is recognised; Advaita holds that the relata are finally unreal; recognition theories hold that standing is conferred by recognition; and the sciences describe relationships as arrangements that valuers value. Only the first supports the claim that a relationship can be failed by both parties without either noticing.

5.4 Objectivity and the is–ought gap

Advaita and Madhyasth Darshan are both value realists and reach that position by opposite routes: Advaita by denying that the plural world is real, Madhyasth Darshan by holding that value is what plural units essentially are. Neither accepts the framing in which an inference from fact to value must be licensed, because for neither is the evaluative fact a separate fact. Western philosophy takes the gap seriously and divides over whether it can be closed. The sciences accept it and stay on the factual side, which is why their results constrain axiology without settling it.

5.5 Commensurability and aggregation

All four positions reject a simple single scale, for different reasons. Madhyasth Darshan rejects it structurally, because its values are harmonies between distinct pairs of faculties. Advaita rejects it asymmetrically, because the highest value differs in kind from all others. Western pluralism rejects it on the strength of conflict cases and the failure of comparative relations. Applied science rejects it empirically, because proxies chosen for aggregation demonstrably misdirect the activity they measure.

Yet the darshan and Western pluralism draw opposite conclusions from the same structural claim. Berlin's incommensurability implies that some conflicts are tragic and rationally unresolvable. Madhyasth Darshan implies that no conflict among genuine values is finally irresolvable, since coexistence is orderly and apparent conflict indicates mis-evaluation. This is the most consequential single divergence in the comparison, and the darshan's position is the more demanding: it must hold that every real value conflict is a symptom of error, and §7.7 asks whether the texts supply a procedure adequate to that claim.

5.6 Value ranks: Madhyasth Darshan and Scheler

The two closest positions in this comparison deserve their own contrast. Both hold that values are objective and ranked, that value-cognition is non-inferential, that height is bound up with durability, and that whole traditions can invert the ranking. They differ in three respects. Scheler grounds the ranks in *a priori* value essences apprehended in feeling; Madhyasth Darshan grounds them in the participation of units in an orderly coexistence, giving it an ontological rather than phenomenological warrant. Scheler's hierarchy ends in the holy; the darshan's ends in coexistence and has no sacred category. And Scheler's value-cognition is available to ordinary intentional feeling, while the darshan requires an achieved transformation of the evaluator, which makes its axiology dependent on its account of awakening in a way Scheler's is not.

The comparison also shows what the darshan gains from its ontology. Scheler's most persistent difficulty is explaining why the ranks are as he says, given that the evidence for them is the feeling that discloses them. Madhyasth Darshan can point to durability and to participation in orderliness as independent marks of height — at the price of the circularity examined in §7.2.

5.7 Kinds of value in the economy

The darshan's usefulness value, aesthetic addition, and symbolic value line up against use-value, exchange-value, utility, and capability without matching any of them. Its critique of money as symbolic value shares Marx's structure — a token of exchange usurping the place of the thing valued — without the theory of exploitation or the historical account of modes of production. Its constancy claim for usefulness value is stronger than anything in classical economics and is in tension with the marginalist point that usefulness at the margin varies with quantity and context. Its orientation of production to assessed need is closer to the capability approach than to either classical or neoclassical economics, since both the darshan and Sen refuse to let realised preference stand as the measure of what people should be able to do.

5.8 Partially incommensurable criteria of evaluation

The traditions do not merely disagree about values; they disagree about what would settle a disagreement. For Madhyasth Darshan the evidence is fulfilment in relationship, evaluated result, and mutual satisfaction sustained across a tradition. For Advaita it is realisation of the Self, before which relational evidence is provisional. For Western philosophy it is argument tested against considered judgments. For the sciences it is replicable measurement.

None of these can be substituted for another without loss. Mutual satisfaction is not a replicable measurement, and a replicable measurement of reported satisfaction is not the fulfilment of a relationship's inherent expectation. This is why the comparison in §5.2 can be stated but not adjudicated by a neutral procedure — a limitation this study shares with [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §5.3, and one worth stating rather than papering over.

6. Critical Review

6.1 Madhyasth Darshan — a coherent value realism with an undischarged criterion

Strengths.

- Value is derived from the ontology rather than added to it, so the darshan does not face the is–ought problem in the form that constrains most modern positions.
- The definitions are unusually operational for a value theory. Trust is fulfilment, not confidence; dispassion is evaluative accuracy, not indifference; kindness, grace, and compassion are separated by the objective condition of the recipient rather than by the agent's feeling.
- The non-substitutability of the four harmonies is a structural result rather than a moral intuition, and it gives the darshan a principled reason to refuse aggregation that most objective-list theories lack.
- The three failure modes of evaluation — over, under, and mis — give a taxonomy of moral error that does not reduce to weakness of will, ignorance of fact, or bad rules, and that applies to whole traditions as readily as to individuals.
- The account of value transmission is consistent with its axiology: higher value attracts, glory is emulation without resistance, and value education is the social form of both. Nothing has to be added to explain why understanding should spread.

Weaknesses.

- The correctness criterion is not independently exercisable. Correct evaluation requires awakening; awakening is evidenced by correct evaluation, fulfilled relationships, and mutual satisfaction. The circle is not vicious as a description of an integrated life, but it does not adjudicate a disputed case.
- The rooting chain of §1.9 is stated as a closed cycle without an account of how any member can be corrected from outside it.

- Mutual satisfaction is doing heavy evidential work while remaining unspecified as a public test. The darshan gives no procedure for the case where both parties are satisfied and a third party judges the relationship exploitative, or where satisfaction is asymmetric by long habituation.
- The constancy of usefulness value is asserted rather than argued and is in tension with ordinary facts about scarcity, substitution, and technological change.
- The list of nine established values is given without derivation from the taxonomy of §1.3. Nothing in the account explains why there are these nine, or what would settle a proposal to add or remove one.
- The claim that no conflict among genuine values is finally irresolvable is the darshan's most demanding commitment and the least supported by procedure.

Madhyasth Darshan offers the most fully integrated value theory of the four positions examined here, and its integration is purchased by making the criterion of correct evaluation internal to the transformation it recommends.

6.2 Advaita Vedanta — a secure ultimate value, a thin relational one

Strengths.

- The argument that a value which can be gained and lost cannot be the final good is rigorous and has never been satisfactorily answered by eudaimonist or hedonist accounts.
- The Maitreyi teaching gives a unified explanation of why finite goods both attract unconditionally and disappoint, which competing theories explain only piecemeal.
- Locating the highest value in what one already is removes the regress that afflicts accounts in which the good must be produced.
- The qualification structure states plainly what a seeker must already possess, rather than treating value-recognition as available on demand.

Weaknesses.

- Relational value has no secure ground. If the relata are finally unreal, the value of a fulfilled relationship cannot be final, and *loka-sangraha* explains why the liberated act without explaining why the relationship matters.
- The tradition's account of empirical value is largely negative, so it has little to say about how competing legitimate goods should be ordered within the world.
- The bliss identification is textually secure but resists any independent check, since the evidence for it is realisation and the criterion of realisation is given within the tradition.

Advaita secures the ultimate value more tightly than any other position considered here and pays for it with the provisionality of everything else.

6.3 Modern Western axiology — sharp distinctions without a settled ground

Strengths.

- The distinctions are genuine advances: intrinsic against final value, value against reasons, height against urgency, dignity against price, modes of valuation against amounts of value.
- The negative results are robust. Value is not identical with pleasure, with satisfied preference, or with market price, and each of these has been shown to fail by argument rather than assertion.
- Value pluralism and incommensurability are developed with a precision no other tradition matches, and Scheler and Hartmann show that an objective ranked axiology can be worked out in detail.
- The field is self-correcting: each family's difficulties are stated by its own proponents.

Weaknesses.

- The objectivity question is no closer to resolution than it was a century ago, and each family's epistemology of value inherits its metaphysics' problems.
- Fitting-attitude and response-dependent accounts have difficulty explaining large-scale evaluative error without idealising responses to the point where the correctness of the idealisation becomes the original question.
- The separation of questions that gives the field its rigour also leaves it without an integrated account: theories of well-being, of moral obligation, and of economic value are pursued largely independently.

Western axiology has mapped the space of positions more carefully than any other tradition and has not established which of them to hold.

6.4 Natural and social sciences — real measurement of valuation, no verdict on value

Strengths.

- The mechanisms of valuation are genuinely known in outline, and the finding that valuation is computed against expectation explains a large class of evaluative errors.
- Well-being research has established empirically that well-being is not one quantity, supporting a claim philosophy could only argue for.
- The evolutionary and cross-cultural evidence shows that valuing is not arbitrary, which constrains relativist positions.
- The specification and alignment literature supplies independent, practical evidence that optimising a proxy destroys the value it stood for.

Weaknesses.

- The methods measure valuation and cannot distinguish valuing well from valuing badly; every apparent verdict on value comes from a value premise in the choice of measure.
- The common-currency finding is often over-read as showing that value is single-scaled, when it shows only that choice requires comparison.
- Adaptation results are frequently presented as showing that circumstances do not matter, which does not follow from the transience of reported affect.

- Debunking and vindicating readings of the evolutionary evidence are both consistent with it, and the science cannot choose between them.

The sciences constrain axiology substantially and settle none of its questions, which is what their methods were built to do.

7. Open problems for Madhyasth Darshan axiology

7.1 The structure of the higher–lower ordering

The darshan uses two apparatuses: a classification of six perspectives into inhumane and humane, and a comparative ranking of higher and lower value. Whether these are one ordering or two is not settled by the texts. If higher and lower value form a single ordering, the darshan has something close to a scale and owes an account of why it is not a maximand. If the ordering is domain-relative, it owes an account of how cross-domain comparisons — a gain in prosperity against a loss in trust — are made at all. The definition of higher value as resolved outlook and lower value as tendency for problems (MVD, p. 126) suggests a single ordering by tendency towards resolution, which is the more defensible reading and the one in most tension with the non-substitutability of the four harmonies.

7.2 Value realism and the awareness-dependence of evaluation

The darshan asserts both that value is established in every unit (SB, p. 87) and that in the absence of awareness there is no determination of value (KD, p. 23). Taken as a distinction between value and its determination, the pair is coherent and is the position defended in §1.13. What remains open is whether the darshan can identify a correct determination without already assuming the awakening that is supposed to guarantee it. The rooting chain of §1.9 closes the circle explicitly. A response is available in principle — that convergent evidence from result, relationship, and tradition constrains evaluation from several directions at once — but the texts do not develop it, and its development is the most valuable work an interpreter could do here.

7.3 Mutual satisfaction as public evidence

Mutual satisfaction is the terminus of justice (MVD, p. 336) and therefore the darshan's principal public evidence that value has been fulfilled. Three cases are unaddressed. Where both parties are satisfied and an outside observer judges the relationship exploitative, the darshan must either accept the parties' verdict or appeal to a standard beyond satisfaction, and it does not say which. Where satisfaction is asymmetric because one party's expectations have been shaped downward by long habituation, satisfaction registers the adaptation rather than the fulfilment. And where a relationship's obligations extend to parties not present — future generations, distant others — mutual satisfaction has no purchase. The first two are the problems that adaptive preference raises for preference-based welfare theory (§3.8), arriving by a different route.

7.4 Does participation derive value or presuppose it?

Identifying value with essentiality and locating human value in participation in orderliness dissolves the is–ought problem only if “orderliness” is not itself an evaluative term. If orderliness means whatever pattern obtains, then participation in it carries no normative weight. If it means the pattern in which units reach completeness and coexistence is sustained, then the value is already in the description, and the darshan has offered a definition rather than a derivation. The texts point to the second, and the definition may be a good one; but the darshan should not also claim to have crossed the is–ought gap, since on this reading it has declined to enter it. The comparison with neo-Aristotelian naturalism in §3.2 faces the same question in the same form.

7.5 The constancy of usefulness value

The claim that a kilogram of sesame seeds has always had the same value (JV, p. 137) is the darshan’s most exposed empirical assertion. Read as saying that the object’s own capacities do not change with market conditions, it is defensible and is a real corrective to price-based thinking. Read as saying that usefulness itself is constant, it faces obvious counter-cases: usefulness depends on available technique, on what else is available, on quantity already held, and on the purpose in view. Antibiotics lose usefulness as resistance spreads; a fuel loses usefulness when the engines that burn it are gone. The darshan needs the first reading, and the texts do not clearly distinguish it from the second.

7.6 The status of the list of nine

JV’s nine established values (JV, p. 108) are given as a list, and MVD defines each of them, but nothing derives the nine from the taxonomy of value classes or shows the list to be complete. Since the darshan is elsewhere precise about enumerations — the six perspectives, the ten activities of *jeevan*, the two, four, sixteen, thirty-six, and sixty-four activities of the faculties — the absence of a derivation here is conspicuous. Two questions follow: whether the nine are meant as exhaustive, and what would settle a proposal to add a value that the tradition has not named.

7.7 Conflict between two just claims

If no conflict among genuine values is finally irresolvable (§5.5), the darshan needs a procedure for cases where two recognised relationships make incompatible claims and both fulfilments are just. The texts supply the widening chain from justice to *dharma* to truth, which locates where the question is to be reconsidered, but not a method for deciding. Absent such a method, the claim that apparent conflict indicates mis-evaluation risks becoming unfalsifiable: any residual conflict can be attributed to an error not yet found.

7.8 The transmission circle

Value education is the darshan’s mechanism for making correct evaluation available, and correct evaluation is what qualifies a person to conduct it. This is the axiological form of the problem identified in [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §7.5. The darshan’s own resources for addressing it are the natural attraction of lower value towards higher value (MVD, p. 222) and glory as emulation without resis-

tance (MVD, p. 335) — mechanisms that require no prior qualification in the learner. Whether they suffice to bootstrap a tradition, and how they are to be distinguished from ordinary prestige-following, is not worked out.

7.9 Value in the other orders and the boundary of right-use

Holding that value is established in every unit gives the darshan a strong basis for right-use and a corresponding difficulty in drawing its boundary. If a plant, a mineral, and an animal each have essentiality that is their value, the darshan needs to say why using them is not a violation of that value, and why some uses are right and others exploitative. The available answer is that right-use is participation in the orderliness in which each order finds completeness, with regeneration as the measure (SB, p. 141). That is a real criterion, and it is not obviously sufficient to settle the harder cases — animal use, habitat conversion, and the treatment of the animal order in particular, given the darshan's own position on vegetarian food (SB, p. 201).

7.10 Translation load on *mulya* and *bhav*

Mulya carries value, worth, and price in the source language, and the translations render it by all three. *Bhav* is rendered as sentiment, value, and meaning in different passages, and MVD's glossary defines it as "Value, evaluation" (MVD, p. 326) while the rooting chain treats sentiment and evaluation as distinct members of one series (MVD, p. 83). Readers of the English texts can easily take a claim about *bhav* as psychological when it is axiological, or take the constancy of *mulya* as a claim about price. The Editorial Notes below record the conventions adopted here.

8. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan holds that value is the essentiality of a unit as it participates in coexistence; that value is therefore established in every unit, insentient and sentient alike; and that what the human being contributes is evaluation rather than value. From these three commitments the rest of its axiology follows without further premises. Values are recognised, not created, which is why relationship must be recognised before its values can flow. Evaluation is an activity with a name, a location, and three specific failure modes, which is why moral error can be described precisely without appeal to weakness of will. The four *jeevan* values are harmonies between distinct pairs of faculties, which is why nothing in the darshan can serve as a single maximand. And correct evaluation is recognition of what a unit essentially is, which is why the darshan takes itself to have no is–ought gap to cross.

The system's integration is its strength and the source of its principal difficulty. Because the criterion of correct evaluation is essentiality, and essentiality is accessible only to an evaluator who has achieved awakening, the darshan cannot exhibit its criterion to someone who does not already share its account of the evaluator. Mutual satisfaction, evaluated result, and humane tradition are offered as public evidence, and they are genuine constraints; they are not yet a procedure for adjudicating a disputed evaluation, and the texts do not supply one.

Set against the other positions, the darshan's distinctive contributions are three. It grounds a ranked, objective axiology in an ontology rather than in phenomenology or intuition, which is what separates

it from Scheler's closely parallel system. It holds the plurality of values together with the claim that value conflict is finally resolvable, which no Western pluralism attempts. And it treats value as fully real in the non-human orders while locating evaluation exclusively in the human, which gives right-use a basis that neither instrumental nor rights-extension environmental ethics provides.

What remains open is not whether the account is coherent — it is more tightly coherent than most — but whether its central criterion can be exercised. Advaita secures its highest value by making everything else provisional. Western axiology maps the alternatives and settles none. The sciences measure valuation and decline the question. Madhyasth Darshan answers the question directly and stakes the answer on a transformation of the evaluator, which is a substantive claim about human beings and not a definition. Whether that claim can be shown to hold in a way that survives disagreement is the question its axiology leaves to be worked out.

Appendix: Quick Glossary

Terms in §1

- **Mulya** — value. In this darshan the essentiality of a unit as it participates in coexistence, not a preference, a price, or a conferred property.
- **Maulikta** — essentiality, fundamental distinctiveness. What a unit distinctively is in the whole; identified with value at SB, p. 50.
- **Mulyankan** — evaluation. The knowledge-order activity of determining what a value is and whether it has been fulfilled.
- **Bhav-kriya** — sentiment activity. The single activity comprising values and their evaluation (MVD, p. 203).
- **Bhav** — sentiment; glossed in MVD's appendix as "Value, evaluation" (MVD, p. 326).
- **Vastu mulya** — object value. The usefulness of an insentient or produced unit; "spread everywhere" and not inherent in *jeevan*.
- **Upyogita mulya** — usefulness value. The constant value of an object for a purpose.
- **Prateek mulya** — symbolic value. Money as token of exchange; accumulable and not the value of any object.
- **Jeevan mulya** — the four values of *jeevan*: happiness, peace, contentment, bliss, as harmonies between adjacent faculties.
- **Manav mulya** — human values. The *dharma* and essential nature of the human being as such.
- **Sthapit mulya** — established values. The nine values inherent in recognised relationships.
- **Guru mulya** / ***laghu mulya*** — higher and lower value. Ranked by tendency towards resolution and by durability of result, not by intensity.
- **Avamulyan** / ***adhimulyan*** — under-evaluation and over-evaluation; with mis-evaluation, the three failure modes of the sentiment activity.
- **Abhiman** — conceit. Imposed evaluation, characterised by the three failure modes.

- **Asakti** — attachment. Believing mistakes made towards decline to be correct.
- **Ubhaya sukrti** / ***ubhaya vikrti*** — mutual ascent and mutual descent. Movement towards higher value with durability, or towards lower value with short-lasting result.
- **Pratikranti** — retrogression. Movement towards mutual descent upon coming together.
- **Nirvah** — fulfilling. Proving a relationship's values through use, right-use, and complementariness.
- **Pahchan** — recognition. Identifying a relationship and its inherent purpose, without which values do not flow.
- **Kshamata, yogyata, *patrata*** — capacity, ability, receptivity. The conditions that mediate whether a recognised value is actually fulfilled.
- **Ubhaya tripti** — mutual satisfaction. The terminus of justice and the darshan's principal public evidence of value-fulfilment.
- **Sadupyog** — right-use. Use that serves the purpose for which a resource has value, within regeneration.
- **Daya, kripa, *karuna*** — kindness, grace, compassion; distinguished by whether the recipient lacks content, receptivity, or both (MVD, p. 61).
- **Samajikta** — sociality. Fulfilling the values inherent in relationships and associations (MVD, p. 56).

Terms in §2

- **Purushartha** — human end. *Dharma, artha, kama*, and *moksha*, with *moksha* as the highest.
- **Ananda** — bliss. In Advaita, the nature of Brahman rather than a state produced by action.
- **Priyata** — dearness. In BU 2.4.5, traced to the Self as its single source.
- **Sadhana-chatushtaya** — the fourfold qualification: *viveka, vairagya*, the six treasures, and *mumukshutva*.
- **Vairagya** — dispassion as turning away from the non-eternal; contrast MVD's definition as freedom from the three evaluative flaws.
- **Loka-sangraha** — the holding-together of the world; the ground of the liberated person's continued action.
- **Mithya** — neither real nor unreal; the status of the world at the level of final truth.

Terms in §3

- **Intrinsic and final value** — valuable in virtue of intrinsic properties; valuable for its own sake. Distinguished in later work on Moore.
- **Organic unity** — a whole whose value is not the sum of its parts' values.
- **Open question argument** — Moore's objection that for any natural analysis of goodness it remains open whether what satisfies it is good.
- **Fitting-attitude account** — the view that to be valuable is to be a fitting object of pro-attitudes.

- **Buck-passing** — Scanlon’s view that being valuable is not itself reason-giving but indicates that other properties give reasons.
- **Incommensurability** — the failure of the comparative relations a single scale would require.
- **Dignity and price** — Kant’s distinction between what admits of no equivalent and what has one.
- **Wertfühlen** — Scheler’s value-feeling: intentional feeling with its own cognitive adequacy.
- **Value-inversion** — Scheler’s account of a ranking systematically reversed, as in *ressentiment*.
- **Use-value and exchange-value** — what a good does; what it trades for.
- **Capability** — Sen’s measure of what a person is actually able to do and be.

Terms in §4

- **Reward prediction error** — the difference between received and expected reward, encoded by dopaminergic activity.
- **Common currency** — a comparable quantity into which heterogeneous options are converted before choice.
- **Hedonic adaptation** — the return of reported well-being towards baseline after changes in circumstance.
- **Easterlin paradox** — the absence of long-run within-country gains in reported happiness alongside rising income.
- **Experienced and evaluative well-being** — momentary affect against reflective life assessment.
- **Self-determination theory** — the account of autonomy, competence, and relatedness as non-substitutable basic needs.
- **Goodhart’s law** — a measure adopted as a target ceases to be a good measure.
- **Specification gaming** — optimising a stated objective in a way that defeats its purpose.

Editorial Notes

Translating *mulya*

Mulya is rendered as “value” throughout the analytical prose of this study, reserving “price” for monetary exchange and “worth” for no technical use. The Rakesh Gupta translations use “value” for the axiological sense and occasionally “usefulness” as a gloss in the object-value passages; block quotes keep the translation’s wording. Where a passage could be read as making a claim about price, this is flagged in the surrounding prose (§§1.12, 7.5).

Bhav as sentiment, value, and meaning

MVD’s appendix defines *bhav* as “Value, evaluation” (MVD, p. 326), while the rooting chain at MVD, p. 83 treats sentiment and evaluation as distinct members of one series, and MVD, p. 125 states “Sentiment = Essentiality”. This study takes the appendix definition as the systematic one — *bhav* names the axiological content and its determination together — and reads the rooting chain as

analysing that single activity into dependent moments rather than into separate faculties. “Sentiment” is retained as the running English term because the translations use it, but the term carries no psychological or affective implication here.

The nine established values

JV, p. 108 names nine values in prose — care, guidance, trust, affection, gratitude, glory, love, reverence, and respect — and MVD’s appendix defines each. Secondary presentations of Jeevan Vidya sometimes give a different count or order. This study quotes the primary list and treats the number as what the text states rather than as a derived result; §7.6 records the absence of a derivation as an open problem.

The enumerated activities of *jeevan*

MVD’s appendix enumerates two activities of *atma*, four of *buddhi*, sixteen of *chitta*, thirty-six of *vritti*, and sixty-four of *mun* (MVD, pp. 328, 329, 332, 339), each defined as a value or a state, alongside eight activities of visualisation within *chitta* (MVD, p. 327). These are the expansion of the ten named activities of *jeevan* used in [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.7, not a rival enumeration. This study draws its value vocabulary from that appendix and does not attempt a complete reconstruction of the five sets.

“Constant” object value

The constancy asserted at JV, p. 137 is read here as constancy of the object’s own capacity to serve a purpose, not as constancy of usefulness in every context. The passage does not itself draw the distinction; §7.5 sets out why the study adopts the narrower reading and what the wider one would cost.

Value in Western axiology and in Madhyasth Darshan

“Value” in Western axiology is a normative property or relation whose bearer and grounding are contested. In Madhyasth Darshan it is the essentiality of a unit, which makes it a fact about the unit’s being rather than a further property. The mapping used in §§3 and 5 aligns the two only for the purpose of comparison; no claim is made that a single concept is at work.

Citation of KD

Manav Karm Darshan is cited from the working English translation held in this repository, using its page markers. That translation is not a published edition; its formulations, particularly in the front matter and *Foreword* from which several axiological statements in §1 are drawn, should be checked against the Hindi before being relied on for close argument.

References

Madhyasth Darshan (primary sources)

- **MVD** — Nagraj, A. [*Madhyasth Darshan – Co-existentialism, Part 1: Holistic View of Human Behaviour*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: gratitude, glory, and simplicity defined (p. 37); gratitude-to-coexistence chain and conceit as imposed evaluation (p. 38); mutual ascent (p. 44); sociality (p. 56); right-use sequence (p. 55); inhumane perspective (p. 58); humane perspectives (p. 60); kindness, grace, compassion, and the higher-humane perspective (p. 61); six perspectives, profit as higher-for-lower exchange, and the three ways higher value is surrendered (p. 67); trust and affection (p. 73); rooting chain of language, sentiment, essentiality, and evaluation (p. 83); embracing and discarding (p. 84); self-evaluation as first step (p. 87); mutual ascent, mutual descent, inspiration, and retrogression (p. 110); essential nature as value of self, and attachment (p. 124); *dharma* and essential nature of humans, sentiment as essentiality (p. 125); higher value as resolved outlook (p. 126); dispassion as freedom from the three flaws (p. 152); money as symbolic value (p. 183); conceit (p. 185); sentiment activity and the three failure modes of evaluation (p. 203); ascension and descension cause (p. 219); followership and higher value (p. 220); lower value attracted to higher value (p. 222); appendix enumerations of the activities of *jeevan* and their values (pp. 326–343), including visualisation (p. 327), *atma* and *buddhi* (p. 328), *chitta* (p. 329), love, contentment, and abundance (p. 331), guidance, reverence, and *vritti* (p. 332), care and *mun* (p. 339), respect, affection, and generosity (p. 340); trust and justice as the four-step sequence (p. 336); justice (p. 311).
- **SB** — Nagraj, A. [*Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad \(Resolution Centred Materialism\)*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: essentiality as value and its reciprocation in mutuality (p. 50); values recognised only through *jeevan*, and evaluation only upon awakening (p. 64); art of living in recognising relationships and values (p. 65); essential nature manifest as values in every unit (p. 87); values and evaluation as *jeevan*'s purpose (p. 92); relationship-fulfilment observed wherever relationships are recognised (p. 108); justice as recognition, fulfilment, and evaluation (p. 114); recognising relationships and performing evaluation among universal human attributes (pp. 122, 134); delusion as over-, under-, and mis-evaluation (p. 146); evaluation of natural treasure by usefulness and regeneration (p. 141); Ch. 11, *Fear and Temptation or Values and Evaluation* (pp. 199 ff.); human essentiality as the basis of evaluation (pp. 200–201).
- **JV** — Nagraj, A. [*Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: the four classes of value to be comprehended, and the critique of the profit-and-loss cycle (p. 43); values realised through recognition of relationships, and humane conduct as values, character, and ethics (p. 55); the nine established values and the seven relationships (p. 108); usefulness value and aesthetic addition (pp. 137–138); *jeevan* values as harmonies, taste activity, and values inherent in *jeevan* (p. 138); object value spread everywhere while the other classes are inherent in *jeevan*, and evaluation without external instrument (p. 139).
- **KD** — Nagraj, A. *Manav Karm Darshan* (Madhyasth Darshan, Part 2). [Working English translation](#); [Hindi–English review edition](#). Cited: value in the derivation from desire to

realisation (p. 4); determination of practical values through deliberation, and practical values meaningful in humaneness (p. 16); practical value as stable value, and no contact or relationship devoid of value (p. 20); presence as distinctiveness, value, and meaning, and value undetermined in the absence of awareness (p. 23); self-value as the satisfaction of activity and cessation (p. 46); relationship, value, evaluation, balance (p. 51); values with relationships and the dedication of objects (p. 63); humane conduct as value, character, and ethics, and evaluation on the basis of fundamental distinctiveness (p. 67). The English text is a working translation; quoted formulations should be checked against the Hindi.

Advaita Vedanta (primary texts)

- **BU** — [*Bṛihadaranyaka Upanishad*](#). English translation by Swami Madhavananda. Cited: the Maitreyi teaching that all dearness is for the sake of the Self (2.4.5); hearing, reflection, and contemplation (2.4.5).
- **TU** — [*Taittiriya Upanishad*](#). English translation by Swami Gambhirananda. Cited: the sheaths and the innermost *ananda* (2.1–2.5).
- **BG** — [*Bhagavad Gita with the Commentary of Shankaracharya*](#). English translation by Swami Gambhirananda. Cited: prescribed action without attachment to fruit (3.8); *loka-sangraha* and action by the enlightened (3.20, 3.25–26); divine qualities (16.2–16.3).
- **BSB** — Shankara, Adi. [*Brahma Sutra Bhashya*](#). English translation by Swami Gambhirananda. Cited: liberation as eternally accomplished and obscured by ignorance; the *Adhyasa Bhashya* on superimposition.
- **VC** — [*Vivekachudamani*](#) (traditionally attributed to Shankara; authorship disputed). English translation by Swami Madhavananda. Cited as a later pedagogical witness: qualification and the fourfold discipline (vv. 17–20, 69, 82); Existence-Knowledge-Bliss (v. 152).

Related studies in this collection

- [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) — form, properties, essential nature and *dharma* (§1.3), the four orders (§1.5), *jeevan* faculties (§1.7), evaluative perspectives and the dual role of justice (§§1.12–1.12.1), and the four goals with the five social dimensions (§1.15).
- [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) — knowing, believing, recognising, fulfilling, and evaluating (§1.5), karma and evaluated result (§1.7), and the transmission problem (§7.5).
- [Ethics and Morals in Human Beings](#) — the six perspectives as an ethical hierarchy (§3.2), and character and right-use (§§3.5–3.6).
- [Aesthetics](#) — usefulness and the aesthetic addition (§4.1), and taste as the savouring of values (§4.5).
- [Human Behavior and Society](#) — why human fulfilment is not a scalar variable, and the limits of optimisation (§§2.1.1–2.1.6).
- [How to Form Self-Sustaining Organizations](#) — organisations grounded in fear or accumulation, and the alternative.

- *Prosperity Economics and Right Use* (Ongoing) — production, exchange, cyclical economics, and the limits of accumulation, developing §1.12.
- *Family Relationships and Values* (Ongoing) — the individual established values in family living, developing §1.6.
- *Education and Sanskar* (Ongoing) — consciousness-development value education, developing §7.8.

Modern Western philosophy

- **Anderson 1993** — Anderson, E. [*Value in Ethics and Economics*](#). Harvard University Press. Cited: plural modes of valuation (§3.6).
- **Berlin 1969** — Berlin, I. [“Two Concepts of Liberty.”](#) In *Four Essays on Liberty*. Oxford University Press. Cited: conflict among fundamental values (§3.6).
- **Chang 1997** — Chang, R. (ed.) [*Incommensurability, Incomparability, and Practical Reason*](#). Harvard University Press. Cited: modes of comparative failure (§3.6).
- **Hartmann 1932** — Hartmann, N. [*Ethics*](#), 3 vols. Trans. S. Coit. Allen & Unwin. Cited: criteria of value height, and height against urgency (§3.7).
- **Hegel 1807** — Hegel, G. W. F. [*Phenomenology of Spirit*](#). Cited: mutual recognition (§3.9).
- **Honneth 1995** — Honneth, A. [*The Struggle for Recognition*](#). MIT Press. Cited: recognition as a condition of self-realisation (§3.9).
- **Hume 1739** — Hume, D. [*A Treatise of Human Nature*](#), Book III. Cited: the passage from *is* to *ought* (§3.2).
- **Kant 1785** — Kant, I. [*Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*](#). Cited: dignity and price (§3.6).
- **Marx 1867** — Marx, K. [*Capital, Volume I*](#), Part I. Cited: use-value against exchange-value, and money as universal equivalent (§3.8).
- **Moore 1903** — Moore, G. E. [*Principia Ethica*](#). Cambridge University Press. Cited: the naturalistic fallacy, the open question argument, the isolation test, and organic unities (§§3.1–3.2).
- **Noddings 1984** — Noddings, N. [*Caring: A Feminine Approach to Ethics and Moral Education*](#). University of California Press. Cited: the caring relation as primary (§3.9).
- **Nozick 1974** — Nozick, R. [*Anarchy, State, and Utopia*](#). Basic Books. Cited: the experience machine (§3.5).
- **Nussbaum 2011** — Nussbaum, M. [*Creating Capabilities: The Human Development Approach*](#). Harvard University Press. Cited: central capabilities (§3.8).
- **Parfit 1984** — Parfit, D. [*Reasons and Persons*](#), Appendix I. Oxford University Press. Cited: theories of self-interest and global preferences (§3.5).
- **Raz 1986** — Raz, J. [*The Morality of Freedom*](#). Oxford University Press. Cited: incommensurability as failure of comparative relations (§3.6).

- **Scanlon 1998** — Scanlon, T. M. [*What We Owe to Each Other*](#). Harvard University Press. Cited: buck-passing about value (§3.4).
- **Scheler 1913–16** — Scheler, M. [*Formalism in Ethics and Non-Formal Ethics of Values*](#). Trans. M. Frings and R. Funk. Northwestern University Press. Cited: objective ranked values, *Wertfühlen*, the value hierarchy, and value-inversion (§§3.7, 5.6).
- **Sen 1999** — Sen, A. [*Development as Freedom*](#). Oxford University Press. Cited: the critique of utility and the capability approach (§3.8).
- **SEP Value Theory** — Schroeder, M. [“Value Theory.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: the shape of the field (§3.1).
- **SEP Intrinsic vs Extrinsic Value** — Zimmerman, M. J., and Bradley, B. [“Intrinsic vs. Extrinsic Value.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: final and intrinsic value distinguished (§3.1).
- **SEP Well-Being** — Crisp, R. [“Well-Being.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: hedonism, desire theories, and objective lists (§3.5).
- **SEP Moral Realism** — Sayre-McCord, G. [“Moral Realism.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: realist positions and their costs (§3.3).
- **SEP Moral Anti-Realism** — Joyce, R. [“Moral Anti-Realism.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: expressivism, constructivism, and error theory (§3.3).
- **SEP Fitting Attitude Theories** — [“Fitting Attitude Theories of Value.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: value analysed through fitting pro-attitudes (§3.4).
- **SEP Value Pluralism** — Mason, E. [“Value Pluralism.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: plural values and their conflict (§3.6).
- **SEP Incommensurable Values** — Hsieh, N., and Andersson, H. [“Incommensurable Values.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: the structure of comparative failure (§3.6).
- **SEP Scheler** — Davis, Z., and Steinbock, A. [“Max Scheler.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: value ranks and value-feeling (§3.7).
- **SEP Capability Approach** — Robeyns, I., and Byskov, M. F. [“The Capability Approach.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: capabilities against utility (§3.8).
- **SEP Recognition** — Iser, M. [“Recognition.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: recognition and practical standing (§3.9).
- **SEP Trust** — McLeod, C. [“Trust.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: trust as dependence under vulnerability (§3.9).
- **SEP Natural Law Ethics** — Murphy, M. [“The Natural Law Tradition in Ethics.”](#) *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, Winter 2024 archived edition. Cited: grounding goodness in the form of a kind of living thing (§3.2).

Physics, natural and social sciences

- **Amodei et al. 2016** — Amodei, D., Olah, C., Steinhardt, J., Christiano, P., Schulman, J., and Mané, D. [“Concrete Problems in AI Safety.”](#) arXiv:1606.06565. Cited: objective specification as

a central obstacle (§4.6).

- **Crockett 2013** — Crockett, M. J. [“Models of morality.”](#) *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*, 17(8), 363–366. CC BY open-access article. Cited: valuation systems in moral decision-making (§4.1).
- **Curry, Mullins, and Whitehouse 2019** — Curry, O. S., Mullins, D. A., and Whitehouse, H. [“Is It Good to Cooperate? Testing the Theory of Morality-as-Cooperation in 60 Societies.”](#) *Current Anthropology*, 60(1), 47–69. Cited: cross-cultural positive valuation of cooperation (§4.2).
- **Easterlin 1974** — Easterlin, R. A. [“Does Economic Growth Improve the Human Lot? Some Empirical Evidence.”](#) In P. A. David and M. W. Reder (eds.), *Nations and Households in Economic Growth*, 89–125. Academic Press. Cited: the income–happiness paradox (§4.3).
- **Kahneman and Deaton 2010** — Kahneman, D., and Deaton, A. [“High income improves evaluation of life but not emotional well-being.”](#) *PNAS*, 107(38), 16489–16493. Cited: experienced against evaluative well-being (§4.3).
- **Krakovna et al. 2020** — Krakovna, V., et al. [“Specification gaming: the flip side of AI ingenuity.”](#) DeepMind. Cited: catalogued instances of reward hacking (§4.6).
- **Rangel, Camerer, and Montague 2008** — Rangel, A., Camerer, C., and Montague, P. R. [“A framework for studying the neurobiology of value-based decision making.”](#) *Nature Reviews Neuroscience*, 9, 545–556. Cited: common-currency valuation (§4.1).
- **Ryan and Deci 2000** — Ryan, R. M., and Deci, E. L. [“Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being.”](#) *American Psychologist*, 55(1), 68–78. Cited: autonomy, competence, and relatedness as non-substitutable needs (§4.3).
- **Schultz 2016** — Schultz, W. [“Dopamine reward prediction error coding.”](#) *Dialogues in Clinical Neuroscience*, 18(1), 23–32. Cited: reward prediction error (§4.1).
- **Stiglitz, Sen, and Fitoussi 2009** — Stiglitz, J., Sen, A., and Fitoussi, J.-P. [“Report by the Commission on the Measurement of Economic Performance and Social Progress.”](#) Cited: the limits of GDP as a welfare measure (§4.5).
- **Trivers 1971** — Trivers, R. L. [“The Evolution of Reciprocal Altruism.”](#) *The Quarterly Review of Biology*, 46(1), 35–57. Cited: reciprocity without a moral faculty (§4.2).
- **Zak and Knack 2001** — Zak, P. J., and Knack, S. [“Trust and Growth.”](#) *The Economic Journal*, 111(470), 295–321. Cited: generalised trust and economic performance (§4.4).